

Microsoft Sidewinder Precision 2

Features: Three-axis control, eight programmable buttons, hat-switch and an excellent throttle **Price:** Rs 1,200
Contact: Trifen Technologies **Phone:** 022-26236061/6226777
E-mail: trifen@vsnl.com **Web site:** www.microsoft.com

The Microsoft SideWinder Precision 2 is designed exclusively for the Indian gaming market. It incorporates very few cosmetic and functional changes. The base is smaller, lighter and funkier than its older counterpart but sports the same design with a comfortable grip, thumb recess and a comfortably-sized palm rest. While the button layout remains the same, one of the most promising differences is its excellent throttle. The throttle has a sizeable amount of throw angle and thus gives a very linear response.

Since the base was redesigned and made smaller, it weighs less and hampers the stability to an extent; the rubber pegs hold on to the surface, but the stick has a tendency to trip when jerked sideways. The presence of a third axis is laudable considering the price for which it sells in the market.

At Rs 1,200, the eight buttons, hat-switch, excellent throttle, third axis and good build quality. It is reasonably priced for the causal and amateur gamer alike.

Microsoft SideWinder Precision 2		A-
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Saitek ST330 USB Control Stick and Throttle

Features: Rumble effects, USB interface, two-axis control, four programmable buttons **Price:** Rs 2,990 **Contact:** Origin Marketing Pvt Ltd **Phone:** 022-28801335 **E-mail:** origin@vsnl.com
Web site: www.saitek.com

This joystick, in the tradition of all other Saitek joysticks, is ambidextrous in design. The trigger is the same as used in the Cyborg—feather light, with excellent tactile feedback. The head layout is a bit awkward and the palm rest pad is small but provides just enough space.

The buttons are of good quality with an excellent tactile feel and good response. The push throttle is precise and has enough throw-angle for providing linear control over the throttle. The base is appropriately heavy and stable. This stick displayed good rumble effects with precise vibrations. It has only four buttons, rendering itself useless when playing a full-fledged flight simulator. A hat-switch, which should be a standard fitment on a joystick of this class, is also completely missing.

Saitek tried to fit in the excitement of a force feedback joystick into a price of Rs 2,990 and failed—the stick is over priced and misses out on a number of features.

Saitek ST330 USB Control Stick and Throttle		B+
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Saitek Cyborg 3D USB Gold

Features: Customisable palm rest, tiltable head assembly, eight programmable buttons, USB interface, push throttle, three-axis control **Price:** Rs 2,990 **Contact:** Origin Marketing Pvt Ltd **Phone:** 022-28801335 **E-mail:** origin@vsnl.com **Web site:** www.saitek.com

The Cyborg 3D USB Gold comes with a new colour scheme, a funky futuristic design, an all new Saitek Gaming Extension (SGE) programming utility and a USB connection.

It sports an ambidextrous design. The height of the stick can be adjusted. For even better customisation, the tilt of the hat switch can be modified to bring it closer or take it further from your thumb. Saitek has thoughtfully supplied an Allen key that gels into the body of the stick and is mounted on its back.

A push throttle is also provided and the trigger button gives a feather touch operation. The operation of the stick is very smooth and does not display any signs of jerkiness.

The accompanying Saitek Gaming Extension (SGE), a programming utility, is quite powerful as far as programming is concerned, but is very tedious to work with.

This futuristic, feature-rich, highly customisable ambidextrous joystick is priced at Rs 2,990.

Saitek Cyborg 3D USB Gold		B+
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Typhoon 3D Joystick

Features: Three-axis control, six programmable buttons, a push throttle **Price:** Rs 825 **Contact:** Hitech Computers **Phone:** 022-24927323 **E-mail:** bom@hitechit.com
Web site: www.anubisline.com

The Typhoon 3D Joystick is cleanly designed without curves or recesses that can increase or decrease usability. It is of an optimum length with a fairly small palm rest. The button layout is perfect, while the base is large with five suction cups to grasp a desk with confidence. The base has a ring throttle and two turbo fire buttons relegated into the background as the trigger buttons, which work smoothly. A third axis offers perfect rudder control.

A secondary fire button and a hat-switch placed above, form the head. The hat-switch is very easy to reach and is quite responsive. The buttons are very tactile, and provide a good feedback. The trigger too is a delight to use with absolutely no force required to push at it. Two buttons are laterally mounted just under the thumb for easy access.

The Typhoon 3D joystick is good where the price-to-feature ratio is concerned—at a price of Rs 825, you get the four buttons, a hat-switch, a ring throttle and a third axis.

Typhoon 3D Joystick		B+
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	